
Freelance Designer Operating System

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Product: Operating System Date: June 12, 2026

SOP 1: Client Intake & Onboarding

Purpose: To standardize the process from initial client contact to signed agreement, ensuring all project parameters are defined before work begins.

Scope: Applies to the Designer and Salesperson/Owner for all new client projects requiring a formal proposal or contract.

Procedure Steps: 1. **Log Lead** — Enter the new client's name, company, contact info, and initial inquiry into the CRM within 2 business hours of first contact. 2. **Schedule Discovery Call** — Send a Calendly link within 24 hours to schedule a 30-minute discovery call. 3. **Conduct Call** — Use the "Discovery Call Checklist" to capture: Project goals, target audience, deliverables, timeline, budget range, and key stakeholders. 4. **Define Scope** — Translate call notes into a bulleted Project Scope document, listing all deliverables (e.g., 3 logo concepts, 5 social media templates, 1 style guide) with clear specifications. 5. **Create Proposal** — Populate the company proposal template with the Project Scope, timeline, milestones, and pricing within 48 hours of the call. 6. **Send Proposal** — Email the proposal PDF with a 7-day validity period and a link to a DocuSign contract. 7. **Follow Up** — If no response within 3 business days, send a scheduled follow-up email. 8. **Send Final Invoice** — Upon signed contract, issue a 50% deposit invoice via accounting software, referencing the contract number. 9. **Trigger Onboarding** — Upon payment confirmation, automatically send the "Welcome & Onboarding" email package via CRM, including: * Link to the client questionnaire. * Access to the project folder in Google Drive. * Link to the project kickoff poll in Calendly. 10. **Schedule Kickoff** — After questionnaire is returned (within 5 business days), schedule a 60-minute kickoff meeting with the client and any internal team members.

Expected Outcome: A fully onboarded client with a signed contract, paid deposit, and a scheduled kickoff meeting, all information centralized in the CRM and project management system.

Related SOPs: SOP 2: Project Execution & Delivery, SOP 3: Invoicing & Payment Processing.

SOP 2: Project Execution & Delivery

Purpose: To manage the design production workflow from kickoff to final file delivery, ensuring quality control and client approval at key stages.

Scope: Applies to the Designer and Project Manager for all active client projects post-onboarding.

Procedure Steps: 1. **Host Kickoff** — Present the confirmed project scope and timeline during the meeting; record and upload video notes to the project folder. 2. **Break Down Tasks** — Within 24 hours of kickoff, create all project milestones and individual tasks in Asana/Trello with assigned due dates. 3. **Conduct Research** — Allocate 1-3 days for gathering client-provided assets, conducting competitor analysis, and creating mood boards. 4. **Develop First Concepts** — Present 2-3 distinct initial design concepts in a mockup for internal review before client presentation. 5. **Submit for Internal Review** — Schedule a 30-minute internal critique with the Creative Lead at least 1 business day before the client deadline. 6. **Present Concepts** — Send a professionally designed PDF presentation to the client, accompanied by a 15-minute video walkthrough explaining design rationales. 7. **Manage Revisions** — Log all client feedback in the project management tool. Implement up to 2 rounds of revisions as per contract; charge for additional

rounds. 8. **Obtain Final Approval** — Send the final design for formal approval via the "Final Approval" form in the client portal. A 2-business-day response window is permitted. 9. **Prepare Final Files** — Upon approval, organize deliverables into three folders: `01_Source_Files` (e.g., AI, PSD), `02_Exported` (e.g., PNG, PDF, JPG), and `03_Style_Guide`. 10. **Deliver & Archive** — Grant client view access to the delivery folder. Archive the complete project folder to cold storage 7 days after delivery.

Expected Outcome: A completed project delivered to specification, with documented approvals and all assets neatly archived for future reference.

Related SOPs: SOP 1: Client Intake & Onboarding, SOP 3: Invoicing & Payment Processing.

SOP 3: Invoicing & Payment Processing

Purpose: To ensure timely and accurate client billing and the systematic application of late-fee policies.

Scope: Applies to the Owner/Operations Manager for all financial transactions related to client projects.

Procedure Steps: 1. **Generate Deposit Invoice** — Create and send the 50% deposit invoice immediately after contract execution, net 15 payment terms. 2. **Generate Milestone Invoice** — For projects >\$500, create a second invoice for 25% at the midpoint of the project timeline. 3. **Track Payment** — Monitor payment status in the accounting software (e.g., QuickBooks). Flag unpaid invoices 2 days past due. 4. **Send First Reminder** — If payment is 5 days late, send the first automated reminder email with a copy of the original invoice. 5. **Apply Late Fee** — If payment is 15 days late, add a 5% late fee to the invoice balance and send a formal late notice. 6. **Initiate Collections** — If payment is 30 days late, suspend all work on the project, issue a final demand letter, and place the account on hold. 7. **Send Final Invoice** — Upon project delivery and final approval, issue the remaining balance invoice with a 10-day payment term. 8. **Send Thank You** — Within 48 hours of receiving final payment, send a personalized thank-you email requesting a testimonial or referral. 9. **Conduct Financial Review** — Monthly, review accounts receivable to ensure the average collection period remains ≤30 days. 10. **Update Project Status** — Upon final payment, mark the project as "Closed" in both the CRM and project management system.

Expected Outcome: 100% of invoices paid within 30 days on average, with clear financial records and a formalized escalation process for overdue accounts.

Related SOPs: SOP 1: Client Intake & Onboarding, SOP 2: Project Execution & Delivery.